

SBTDWS Transformation — Gaps and Recommended Actions

Briefing paper for Commander — input to J3 / Commander engagement

Prepared by SBTDWS | 2026-06-19 | Pre-decisional planning document

Purpose. This paper consolidates every gap and blocker identified across the SBTDWS transformation analysis into a single set of issues the Commander can brief, with a recommended action attached to each. It is organised by who needs to act, not by source document — the Commander should be able to read straight down the page and know what to say and ask for.

Top-line message. SBTDWS can build much of the future model on its own initiative. It cannot deliver the full 2030 role alone — it needs decisions from Higher HQ and PG HQ on validation authority, standards ownership, J-Staff support, and the IW/UW boundary. There is also a narrow, time-limited opportunity to correct two discrepancies between the written planning guidance and verbal direction already given, before the OPORD locks them in.

1. Time-Critical — Resolve Before the OPORD Is Issued

These items have a hard expiry. Once the OPORD is cut, correcting them costs far more — units will already have planned against the wrong assumption.

ACT NOW

Domain scope mismatch

Current written guidance tasks SBTDWS to train and validate units across all six domains (land, sea, air, cyber, electromagnetic, space). Verbal direction already given at the recent J3 working group session de-scopes this to land and partial air now, with the remaining domains assessed for later phasing.

Recommended action: Amend the task wording to reflect a phased domain commitment — land and air now, other domains conditional on future review — before the OPORD is issued. Otherwise units will be tasked, and will plan, against a six-domain standard the Commander has already adjusted informally.

ACT NOW

Naming not yet settled

Written guidance names the 2030 end-state the "All Domain Warfare Centre." Verbal direction at the same J3 session referred to it as the "Multi Domain Warfare Centre" — no formal decision has actually been made either way.

Recommended action: Do not let the OPORD print a name that is still in dispute. Either confirm the name formally now, or mark it "under review" in the OPORD so units are not briefed an identity that may change shortly after release.

ACT NOW

Main effort / supporting effort not reflected

Written task ordering does not clearly separate main and supporting effort. J3 direction has already reprioritised: collective training, validation, mission rehearsal, and tactical experimentation are main effort; courses and individual training are supporting effort and should not expand.

Recommended action: Carry this main/supporting split explicitly into the OPORD so resourcing and tasking decisions downstream don't default back to the old course-centred framing.

ACT NOW

Capability development cell handoff has no date

Direction to hand the capability development cell to the new Innovation Command carries no trigger date or condition.

Recommended action: Attach a concrete trigger date or condition to the OPORD instruction rather than leaving it open-ended — prevents indefinite ambiguity over who owns capability development work in the interim.

ACT NOW

Validation authority assumed, not granted

Written guidance directs SBTDWS to exercise validation responsibility for SAG 9 and SAG 10. No authority has actually been defined — whether SBTDWS can certify, fail, or recommend remediation, or is advisory only.

Recommended action: Flag this as a pre-condition in the OPORD rather than an assumed capability. This is the single biggest credibility risk in the whole transformation — see Section 2 below.

2. Cannot Be Resolved at SBTDWS Level — Requires Higher HQ / PG HQ Decision

SBTDWS has done what it can on each of these. They need to be raised and decided above this level.

HIGHER HQ

Irregular Warfare / Unconventional Warfare boundary undefined

The split between irregular warfare capability being grown across all units and unconventional warfare capability being generated as a specialist hand-off has not been formally defined. This blocks validation standards, curriculum design, and the training pipeline split — it is the single highest-leverage unresolved item above Commandant level.

Ask: Request Higher HQ formally define this boundary so standards work can proceed on a confirmed basis rather than an assumption.

PG HQ

Validation authority undefined

Without a defined authority — certify, fail, recommend remediation, or advisory only — the entire Observer-Trainer cadre investment risks producing reports that commanders can choose to ignore.

Ask: Request PG HQ confirm validation authority ahead of the first validation event.

PG HQ

Validation standards ownership undefined

It is not yet confirmed who writes and endorses the validation standards for the two Study and Evaluation Groups SBTDWS is responsible for. Without this, course and assessment design proceeds against assumed standards that may be rewritten later.

Ask: Request PG HQ nominate a standards owner so curriculum work is not redone after the fact.

Staff support model undefined

SBTDWS does not have its own intelligence, operations, communications, or resourcing staff functions, and no decision has been made on whether these will be grown organically, allocated on an exercise cycle, or provided through liaison. This gates the planned structural reorganisation and the sizing of exercise control capability.

Ask: Request PG HQ decide the staff support model ahead of the planned reorganisation.

RESOURCING DECISION

Single point of failure across four major lines of effort

Validation authority for both Study and Evaluation Groups, the unconventional warfare raising mission, tactical experimentation leadership, and mission rehearsal facility development currently all sit on SBTDWS at the same time, without dedicated resourcing for any individual line. If SBTDWS is under-resourced, every line of effort is exposed simultaneously.

Ask: Make this risk explicit to the Commander and request either additional resourcing or an agreed sequencing so these lines do not compete for the same limited staff at the same time.

3. Commandant Can Act Now — No External Approval Needed

These do not need to wait for the brief outcome. They should be progressed in parallel.

Action	Status	Why it matters
Direct the engagement to formally agree the SBTDWS / J7 lane split for training and validation	Overdue	Lowest-effort, highest-leverage action available — a single tasking unlocks the formal training architecture relationship
Commit, in advance, to visibly backing the first adverse readiness assessment a unit challenges	Pending	Hardest decision on this list, but the precondition for the Observer-Trainer cadre meaning anything at all
Formally endorse the three-wing structural design	Pending	Conceptual only, no resource cost — should be the easiest decision available, and unblocks staff communication of the design

4. Institutional and Cultural — Needs Sustained Command Tone, Not a Single Decision

These barriers are real and already documented. They are not fixed by one decision — they need consistent command attention over time.

Issue	Recommended posture
Inflated pass rates / assessment not credible	Tie directly to the adverse-assessment backing commitment above — structural pressure for honesty, not a separate fix
Weak instructor accountability and feedback	Build into Observer-Trainer accreditation standard from the outset
Mid-level management resistance to change	Treat as the expected and named political risk at the reorganisation point — plan deliberate engagement, not just an announcement
Reliance on contractors for core military skills	Set a visible target date for military ownership and track progress against it
Tendency to protect the appearance of success over honest reporting	Command must visibly reward honest adverse reporting, not just tolerate it

Timeline risk worth stating plainly: the capability build is timed in years; institutional culture typically takes longer to shift than that. There is a real risk the transformation outpaces the cultural change it depends on.

5. Longer Horizon — On the Radar, Not Today's Ask

Item	Owner	Timing
Mission rehearsal facility concept and capital commitment	PG HQ (capital) / Commandant (concept)	Capital planning must begin ahead of the next budget cycle
Capability development cell transition to Innovation Command	PG HQ / Commandant	Within the next year
Formal governance of tactical experimentation with the Warfare Development Centre	J3 / Commandant	Before experimentation activity scales up
All-domain training enablers (cyber, electromagnetic, space)	External enablers, coalition support	Tied to full operating capability, not initial capability
Integration layer connecting courses, capability development, and exercises	No single owner currently assigned	Structural — flag that this still has no assigned owner

This paper is a planning consolidation, not a directive. All figures and statuses reflect SBTDWS's internal analysis as of the date above and should be verified against current J3/PG HQ positions before use in formal correspondence.